

— A FREE FIELD GUIDE FROM

PULLED FROM THE BINDER.

10 touring & production checklists that hold
at scale.

The systems that run on the biggest stages in the world — pulled out of private binders and put in your hands. No theory. Just the real stuff that works.



— WHY THESE TEN

The ten checklists every show actually depends on.

Every production has a hundred moving pieces. These ten are the ones that — when they fail — take the show down with them. They cover the full lifecycle of a tour, from the first conversation about what the artist wants to build, to the last verification before the truck pulls away from the dock.

Use these as a working reference. Print them and stick them in your binder. Run a show through them on paper before the truck rolls. Hand them to a new crew lead so they understand what gets confirmed at every stage.

Skip the mistakes we already made. What's here is what we wish someone had handed us before our first festival run.

— THE TEN, IN ORDER

- 01 **The Artist's Blueprint** — vision, intent, and the show they're trying to build.
- 02 **The Advance Call** — what gets confirmed before you ever roll a truck.
- 03 **The Festival Advance** — how festival-scale differs from club or theater gigs.
- 04 **The Budget Dry-Run** — line items first-timers miss.
- 05 **The Technical Rider Pre-Check** — what gets approved versus ignored.
- 06 **Crew Call & Scheduling** — who you need, when, what they cost.
- 07 **Transpo & Travel Days** — flights, hotels, ground.
- 08 **Hospitality That Doesn't Backfire** — the rider section that breaks most riders.
- 09 **The Day-Of Timeline & Run-Of-Show** — load-in to load-out, with the cue document.
- 10 **Post-Show Settlement** — what to verify before you leave the venue.

— CHECKLIST 01

The Artist's Blueprint.

VISION, INTENT, AND THE SHOW THEY'RE TRYING TO BUILD.

- ☐ **Get the emotional intent in their own words.**

Before any technical conversation, ask the artist what the show should *feel* like. Three words, a sentence, a reference moment — whatever lands. This is the brief everything else maps to.

- ☐ **Pull a list of three reference shows or productions.**

What do they want to feel like? Specific tours, specific moments. References give the production team something concrete to design against and price.

- ☐ **Identify the non-negotiables.**

The gear, the looks, the songs, the moments the artist will not compromise on regardless of budget. Lock these first; everything else flexes around them.

- ☐ **Identify the flex points.**

What's the artist willing to scale up or down depending on budget, venue, or routing? Make this list explicit so trade-offs don't blow up mid-tour.

- ☐ **Define the audience experience priority.**

Front row, back of house, livestream, social cuts — these all reward different production decisions. Pick the audience the show is built for.

- ☐ **Set the energy curve from open to encore.**

Walk-on energy, set midpoint, climax, encore. Map the emotional shape of the show before any technical cue is written.

- ☐ **Confirm visual identity carryover.**

Does the show extend the artist's existing brand world, or build a new one for this run? The answer changes set design, lighting palette, and content choices.

- ☐ **Capture the post-show feeling.**

What do they want people walking out saying? That single sentence is the closing brief — and the test for whether the show actually delivered.

— CHECKLIST 02

The Advance Call.

WHAT GETS CONFIRMED BEFORE YOU EVER ROLL A TRUCK.

- ☐ **Power and electrical service.**
Incoming service amperage, distribution layout, generator backup if outdoor. Confirm phase configuration and distance from stage to source.
- ☐ **Stage dimensions and load capacity.**
Deck height, usable depth, rigging point count, weight limits per point. Get the actual measured numbers, not the website spec sheet.
- ☐ **Load-in access.**
Dock or street-level, ramp, distance from truck to stage, freight elevator dimensions if applicable, time restrictions.
- ☐ **House gear inventory.**
What the venue provides versus what you bring. Get a current inventory in writing — not the rider attached to the contract from two years ago.
- ☐ **Crew availability.**
Local crew count, call times, union jurisdiction or non-union, any specialty calls (riggers, electricians, video techs).
- ☐ **Show timing.**
Doors, opener, headline, hard curfew. Confirm penalties for going past curfew and who the venue will hold accountable.
- ☐ **Day-of contacts with cell numbers.**
Production manager, FOH, monitor engineer, security lead, runner, dock manager. Names plus mobile numbers — not the office line.
- ☐ **Dressing rooms and hospitality access.**
Number of rooms, key/lock access, kitchen availability, refrigeration, dietary capability. Confirm room availability times — not just total hours.
- ☐ **Preferred vendors that work with this venue.**
Audio, lighting, video, backline rental, catering, runners, security. Venues have established vendor relationships that smooth load-in, gear quality, and on-site response time. Ask the venue who they trust before booking external suppliers.

— CHECKLIST 03

The Festival Advance.

HOW FESTIVAL-SCALE DIFFERS FROM CLUB OR THEATER GIGS.

☐ **Festival production office point of contact.**

Direct line to the festival's stage manager or production coordinator — not the artist's manager. Festival-scale moves through their channel, not the booking channel. The advance call also opens the door for everything on the next item to flow back to you.

☐ **Gather everything available, then chase what's missing.**

Most of this comes back from the festival production team in the weeks following the advance call as their plans materialize. Stay on it. Equip the crew and clarify expectations for management and artist with whatever lands: stage plots, lighting plots, site maps, slot scheduling and timing, MVR files for lighting, backline and shared-gear inventory already on stage, photo / video crew contacts and content protocols.

☐ **Slot timing, changeover window, and programming time.**

The actual minutes on stage versus published time. Confirm changeover windows on both ends — that's where slots get cut. Plus when soundcheck happens, when lighting programming time gets allocated, and whether overnight programming windows are available before the slot.

☐ **Shared backline and stage gear.**

What's pooled with other artists, what's exclusive to your slot, who handles changeover. Confirm tuning, levels, and condition before doors.

☐ **Festival credentials and access tiers.**

How many wristbands, what tiers, who gets vehicle/parking access, who gets stage access. Build the list before arrival, not at the gate.

☐ **Stage manager hand-off requirements.**

What they need from you in advance — stage plot, input list, ROS, IEM channels, plus any incoming trucks or equipment you're bringing in. What they'll provide — local crew, shared comms, monitor engineer.

☐ **Comm protocols.**

Festival's preferred radio system and frequencies, code words for cuts and emergencies, who speaks to whom during the slot.

☐ **Sound limit and curfew penalties.**

Decibel cap measured at FOH, time penalties for running long, financial fines per minute over. Discuss the cut plan in advance.

☐ **Festival photographers and content rights.**

Who shoots the slot, who owns the footage, what can be reused on artist channels, what's exclusive to the festival.

— CHECKLIST 04

The Budget Dry-Run.

LINE ITEMS FIRST-TIMERS MISS.

- ☐ **Production fee floor.**
The minimum production cost at this scale before any extras. Get a real number from someone who's done it, not an estimate.
- ☐ **Day-off costs.**
Bus, hotel, per diems on non-show days. Often 25–35% of total tour cost. Easy to underbudget when only counting show days.
- ☐ **Insurance and bonding.**
Production liability, equipment insurance, venues that require additional insureds named on a Certificate of Insurance (COI). Most venues won't release the contract without a current COI — request it by name, in writing, well before load-in.
- ☐ **Local labor multipliers.**
Investigate and have a clear understanding of this show's labor on the front end. Overtime past 8 hours, doubletime past 12, weekend rates, lunch break waivers. Multipliers compound — a 14-hour day is expensive, and surprise labor bills wreck settlement.
- ☐ **Backline and gear: rent vs. ship break-even.**
Calculate where renting locally beats shipping the kit. Usually 4–6 cities of the same gear type, depending on geography.
- ☐ **Catering and per diem real numbers.**
Actual cost per person per day at current prices. Catering rates have moved significantly — last year's number is already out of date.
- ☐ **Tax and royalty line.**
ASCAP, BMI, SoundExchange where applicable, state and city sales tax on merch, withholding for out-of-state crew where required.
- ☐ **Contingency — separate from buffer.**
This is critical. The best plan prepares for things not to go exactly according to plan. Reserve 10–15% for unexpected costs (gear failure, replacement crew, last-minute travel). Not the same as the timeline buffer. Both belong on the budget.

— CHECKLIST 05

The Technical Rider Pre-Check.

WHAT GETS APPROVED VERSUS IGNORED.

- ☐ **Stage plot accuracy.**
Actual measurements, not estimates. Gear positions match what the crew is rolling out of the truck. Plot to scale, with stage edges marked.
- ☐ **Input list parity.**
Channel count matches your console scenes exactly. Include backup channels and spares. Mismatch between input list and console is the most common day-of fight.
- ☐ **Power requirements stated correctly.**
By phase, by amperage, by distance from source. Specify single or three-phase, neutral configuration, and ground requirements.
- ☐ **Backline list with model numbers.**
Exact units, not "a Twin Reverb or similar." If similar substitutions are acceptable, write the substitution clause separately.
- ☐ **Rigging requirements with weight loads.**
Hang points, motor count, rated point loads in pounds. If the venue can't accommodate, that's known before truck arrival, not at load-in.
- ☐ **Comms requirements.**
Channel count, headset count, RF coordination if needed. Specify Clear-Com or Riedel or freelance — assumptions cost time.
- ☐ **Specific gear nuances.**
Preferred cables, mic stand types, monitor wedge models, IEM systems. Detail-driven specificity prevents on-the-fly swaps.
- ☐ **Reasonable substitutions clause.**
Language that lets the venue swap gear within defined limits without re-opening the whole rider. Saves hours of advance back-and-forth.

— CHECKLIST 06

Crew Call & Scheduling.

WHO YOU NEED, WHEN, WHAT THEY COST.

- ☐ **Stagehand count by phase.**
Load-in count, show count, and load-out count are different numbers. Don't bury them in a single line — call them separately.
- ☐ **Specialty calls listed separately.**
Riggers, electricians, audio specialists, video techs. Each is a separate call, separate rate, separate jurisdiction in some cities.
- ☐ **Call times relative to your schedule.**
Earliest crew typically arrives 1–2 hours before truck. Build their call into your timeline, not the other way around.
- ☐ **Lunch break compliance.**
5-hour mark is standard for stagehand union. Confirm whether it's a paid or unpaid break — it varies by local.
- ☐ **Show-call vs. load-out call.**
Same crew or different crew. Different calls mean different rates. Contract this clearly to avoid disputes during settlement.
- ☐ **Catering for local crew.**
Yes / no / snacks-only. This matters more than people admit — it shapes how the crew shows up. Confirm in writing.
- ☐ **Minimum call duration.**
4-hour minimum at most union locals, even if the work takes 90 minutes. Plan accordingly when you're stacking short calls.
- ☐ **Wrap-out and tip protocol.**
Who handles, what's standard, how it varies by city. Document who tipped whom — keeps relationships clean for the next run.
- ☐ **Department-coded wristbands for all stagehands.**
A small thing that goes a long way. Color-coded wristbands assign each stagehand to a department (audio, lighting, video, rigging, backline) so your tour department leads can spot their hands at a glance. Sometimes shared and swapped during long days, but the baseline identification keeps the floor organized and helps everyone hit the ground running.

— CHECKLIST 07

Transpo & Travel Days.

FLIGHTS, HOTELS, GROUND — GETTING THERE AND GETTING BACK.

- ☐ **Build a travel profile for every traveling team member.**

One file per person, packaged so any rebooking, gate issue, or hotel question can be resolved instantly: passport-exact name spellings (no nicknames, exact match to the document being used), date of birth, frequent-flyer / airline rewards numbers, hotel loyalty program numbers, ground transportation accounts, and visa or travel-document status for any international legs.
- ☐ **TSA Pre-Check / CLEAR for everyone traveling.**

Saves hours across a tour. Confirm enrollment status well before tour start — applications take weeks.
- ☐ **Hotel room block deposit and cancellation policy.**

Confirm when the block releases, what the no-show penalty is, who absorbs the cost. Block math goes wrong on day-off cities.
- ☐ **Ground transportation pickup confirmation.**

Driver name, vehicle type, plate or ID, contact cell, exact pickup time and location. Confirm 24 hours out, again 2 hours out.
- ☐ **Bus call versus hotel checkout time.**

Stagger them to avoid lobby chaos. Confirm late-checkout agreements with the hotel block in advance, in writing.
- ☐ **Per diem distribution method.**

Venmo, prepaid card, cash, payroll add-on. Confirm the distribution before tour start, including timing — before or after tax day matters.
- ☐ **Travel-day catering plan.**

When buses move during meal hours, plan ahead. Confirm rest stops, pre-buy snacks, or coordinate a stop with a known catering pickup.
- ☐ **Flight delay and missed-flight protocol.**

Backup itineraries pre-built for key personnel. Who has authority to rebook on the fly. What the show-day fallback looks like.
- ☐ **Integrate a scheduling and itinerary tool.**

Master Tour, Day Sheets, or similar. Central source of truth for travel times, ground pickups, hotel info, and team contact. The whole crew operates off the same dashboard rather than chasing emails. Saves hours per week and prevents the small misalignments that turn into missed flights.

— CHECKLIST 08

Hospitality That Doesn't Backfire.

THE RIDER SECTION THAT BREAKS MOST RIDERS.

- ☐ **Dietary restrictions stated as needs, not preferences.**
"Gluten-free, severe" reads differently than "ideally gluten-free." Be explicit about severity so the venue takes it seriously.
- ☐ **Specific brands only when actually required.**
If any brand will do, say so. Brand-specific demands create venue back-and-forth and look like ego when they're not necessary.
- ☐ **Quantity per person clear.**
"3 cases of water per day" beats "ample water." Vague quantity creates over- or under-supply, both of which are problems.
- ☐ **Dressing room essentials versus extras.**
Split into "must have" and "nice if available." Lets the venue prioritize when they can't deliver everything.
- ☐ **Food timing relative to soundcheck and show.**
Meal hours, post-show dinner, before-bus-pull snacks. Specify the timing so the kitchen can plan.
- ☐ **Allergen disclosure on every dish.**
Labels on every catered item, separate prep for severe allergies. This is non-negotiable when the venue has any responsibility for catering.
- ☐ **Substitution policy in advance.**
What's acceptable to swap if an exact item is unavailable. Saves the runner from a panic call mid-soundcheck.
- ☐ **End-of-night protocol.**
What gets packed out with the bus, what gets left for the venue, what gets thrown out. Document so the venue isn't stuck.

— CHECKLIST 09

The Day-Of Timeline & Run-Of-Show.

LOAD-IN TO LOAD-OUT, WITH THE CUE DOCUMENT.

- ☐ **Master Tour or Day Sheets — single source of truth for the day.**

Every crew member, department head, and runner pulls call times, ROS, and schedule changes from the same scheduling app. Critical for fluid operation. Last-minute changes propagate to everyone instantly. No more half the crew working off Tuesday's email.
- ☐ **Truck arrival and dock access confirmation.**

Confirmed time, who unlocks, who flags in, who has the keys. The first hour going wrong cascades through the day.
- ☐ **Load-in start with realistic buffers.**

The first hour is always slower than planned. Build that into the timeline — don't promise downstream calls based on best-case load-in.
- ☐ **Soundcheck windows by department.**

Audio first, lighting focus, then video sync, then full run. Each department gets a dedicated window — overlap creates problems.
- ☐ **Doors, opener, changeover, headline timing.**

Exact minutes for each transition, not just "after opener finishes." Build a real schedule down to the minute.
- ☐ **Show-call run-of-show distributed pre-show.**

Cue-by-cue document delivered to all department heads. Walk-on, set list anchors, pyro/effects cues, encore protocol — all named.
- ☐ **Curfew enforcement plan.**

What gets cut if the show runs long, decided pre-show — not on stage at minute 90. Communicate the cut order to FOH and stage manager.
- ☐ **Encore and walk-off triggers.**

What signals encore (lights up, walk-off, time check). Confirm the trigger across departments so cues fire on the right cue.
- ☐ **Load-out kickoff trigger.**

When load-out starts — last note, walk-off, lights up, audience clear. Be specific. Load-out time depends entirely on when it actually begins.

— CHECKLIST 10

Post-Show Settlement.

WHAT TO VERIFY BEFORE YOU LEAVE THE VENUE.

- ☐ **Ticket count audit.**

Final settlement number matches turnstile count and ticketing system report. All three should agree before you sign the settlement sheet.

- ☐ **Merch settlement reconciliation.**

Venue split, hall fee, sales reconciliation against starting and ending inventory. Discrepancies get sorted now, not after the bus leaves.

- ☐ **Backstage and hospitality damage walk.**

Venue walks the rooms with you before they release. Document anything pre-existing in writing. Photo it if there's any question.

- ☐ **Local crew tip and wrap-out documentation.**

Tips handed off, signed for, documented in the settlement file. Tracks who got what for the next time you book the same crew.

- ☐ **Returned gear inventory check.**

Every piece of rented backline checked back in — counted and inspected, not just counted. Damage is owned tonight, not next month.

- ☐ **Lost-and-found protocol.**

Venue gets a contact for late-found items. You have 24–48 hours to claim. Anything left longer becomes the venue's call.

- ☐ **Settlement check or wire confirmation.**

Confirm wire timing, confirm receiving account, confirm who at your end will reconcile when the wire lands.

- ☐ **Final production walk.**

Visual check that nothing is left behind — every dock corner, every dressing room, every road case. The walk-through that costs five minutes saves a flight.

- WHAT'S NEXT

The full binder is the next step.

These ten checklists are the surface. Underneath them sit the actual templates — the riders, budgets, run-of-show docs, crew schedules, advance forms, settlement sheets — that the people running the biggest stages in the world use every night.

The Blueprint is the complete library. Every working document, pulled out of private binders and put in your hands. Editable. Plain language. Field-tested across festival-scale runs.

- THE BLUEPRINT • COMPLETE SYSTEM

Every template referenced here, plus everything else in the binder. One package. Lifetime access.

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